CCA-F Self-Study
Complete Resource Guide

Everything you need to self-study for the CCA-F exam — curated from real community guides, official Anthropic materials, and exam-takers' experience.

A focused 3-week day-by-day plan — achievable with consistent daily effort.

01 Exam Snapshot | 02 5 Domains | 03 6 Scenarios | 04 Resources | 05 3-Week Plan | 06 Exam Tips | 07 AI Prompts

Sources: Tutorials Dojo · claudecertifications.com · dev.to · certsafari.com · Udemy · GitHub repos · Official Anthropic docs

01

Exam at a Glance

720

Passing Score
(out of 1000)

MCQ

Format
Scenario-based multiple choice

5

Competency
Domains tested

6

Production Scenarios
(4 randomly chosen per exam)

3 Wks

This plan
Exam-ready in 3 weeks

Mar '26

Exam launched
by Anthropic

KEY INSIGHT: This is NOT a trivia quiz. Every question drops you into a real production situation and asks for an architectural decision. Think: "What would an architect actually do?" — not "what does this parameter do?"

02

The 5 Exam Domains

#	DOMAIN	WEIGHT	KEY FOCUS
D1	**Agentic Architecture & Orchestration**	**27%**	Agentic loops, stop_reason handling, multi-agent coordinator/subagent patterns, task decomposition, context passing, escalation handoffs
D2	**Tool Design & MCP Integration**	**18%**	Writing tool descriptions Claude can understand, structured error responses (errorCategory, isRetryable), MCP server configuration, tool distribution across agents
D3	**Claude Code Configuration & Workflows**	**20%**	CLAUDE.md hierarchy (user/project/directory), .claude/rules/ YAML frontmatter, custom skills with context:fork, plan mode vs direct execution, CI/CD integration
D4	**Prompt Engineering & Context Management**	**22%**	Structured outputs, JSON schema validation, nullable fields to prevent hallucination, context window management, system prompts, few-shot examples
D5	**Production Deployment & Safety**	**13%**	Cost optimisation, latency, model selection (Haiku/Sonnet/Opus), Constitutional AI, responsible deployment, evaluation frameworks, human-in-the-loop design

Domain weights from official CCA-F Exam Guide (Anthropic, 2026).

The 6 Production Scenarios — Exam picks 4 of 6 randomly. Study all 6.

SCENARIO 1

Customer Support Resolution Agent

Build an agent handling returns, billing disputes, account issues. Target: 80%+ first-contact resolution. Key challenge: knowing when NOT to resolve and escalate instead.

Escalation Logic | Tool Use | Handoffs

SCENARIO 2

Code Generation with Claude Code

Team uses Claude Code for code gen, refactoring, debugging, and docs. Configure slash commands, CLAUDE.md setups, understand when plan mode helps vs hurts.

CLAUDE.md | Slash Commands | Plan Mode

SCENARIO 3

Multi-Agent Research System

Coordinator delegates to specialised subagents: search, analyse, synthesise, report. Key: orchestration, context passing, handling partial failures gracefully.

Coordinator/Subagent | Task Tool | Parallel Agents

SCENARIO 4

Developer Productivity Tools

Help engineers navigate codebases and automate grunt work. Heavy focus on built-in tools (Read, Write, Bash, Grep, Glob) and MCP server integration.

Built-in Tools | MCP Servers | Codebase Nav

SCENARIO 5

Claude Code in CI/CD

Automated code reviews, test generation, PR feedback. Know the -p flag, --output-format json, session context isolation, minimising false positives.

-p Flag | JSON Output | CI/CD Integration

SCENARIO 6

Structured Data Extraction

Pull structured data from messy documents. Validate with JSON schemas. Handle nullable fields to prevent hallucination. Design batch processing strategies.

JSON Schema | Nullable Fields | Batch Processing

Curated Self-Study Resources — All 11 resources with direct links

Official CCA-F Exam Guide (PDF)

Official · Free

The single most important doc. Every subdomain, skill, and knowledge requirement. Read first and again before exam day.

→ Download PDF

Anthropic Exam Registration + Courses (Skilljar)

Official

Official exam registration page by Anthropic. Access Anthropic's own Claude courses. Start here to register.

→ anthropic.skilljar.com

claudecertifications.com — 3 Free Courses + 25 Practice Qs

Free · Community

Claude 101 (13 lessons), Claude Code in Action (15 lessons), AI Fluency Foundations. Anti-patterns guide. No signup.

→ claudecertifications.com

CertSafari — 625 Free Practice Questions

Free

625 exam-style questions with detailed rationales, no paywall, no tracking. Domain-specific quiz modes. Most-recommended free resource.

→ certsafari.com

Tutorials Dojo — CCA-F Study Guide

Free

All exam domains, key skills per domain, recommended services to focus on, and a readiness checklist.

→ tutorialsdojo.com

GitHub — paullarionov / claude-certified-architect

Free · Community

Open-source study repo: agent loop lifecycle, tool results, model-driven decision making. Clean markdown format.

→ github.com/paullarionov

GitHub — daronyondem / claude-architect-exam-guide

Free · Community

Community exam guide with scenario walkthroughs and domain notes. Recently updated (May 2026).

→ github.com/daronyondem

Udemy — CCA-F Practice Exams (Tutorials Dojo)

Paid

Realistic timed practice exams aligned to latest blueprint. Detailed question explanations and performance tracking.

→ udemy.com — CCA-F Practice Exams

Udemy — 60 Scenario-Based Practice Questions

Paid

Community-built: 60 scenario MCQs on Claude API, Agent SDK, MCP integrations, structured outputs. Detailed explanations.

→ udemy.com — 60 Scenario Qs

DEV.to — 5 Domains & 6 Scenarios Deep-Dive

Free

Free article breaking down every domain with weights, every scenario with key skills, what separates passing candidates.

→ dev.to article

Anthropic Official Documentation

Official · Free

Core reading: Messages API, Tool Use, Claude Code, Agent SDK, MCP protocol, Model overview (Haiku/Sonnet/Opus).

→ docs.anthropic.com

04

All Study Resource Links — Quick Reference (click any link to open)

Every resource URL in one place.

- Official CCA-F Exam Guide PDF — Official · Free
- claudecertifications.com — Free Courses + Practice Qs — Free · Community
- Tutorials Dojo CCA-F Study Guide — Free
- GitHub: daronyondem / claude-architect-exam-guide — Free · Community
- Udemy: 60 Scenario-Based Practice Questions — Paid
- Anthropic Official Documentation — Official · Free
- Anthropic Exam Registration (Skilljar) — Official
- CertSafari — 625 Free Practice Questions — Free
- GitHub: paullarionov / claude-certified-architect — Free · Community
- Udemy: CCA-F Practice Exams (Tutorials Dojo) — Paid
- DEV.to: 5 Domains & 6 Scenarios Deep-Dive Article — Free

3-Week Self-Study Plan — ~60–90 min/day alongside instructor sessions

WEEK 1
Foundations + Prompting + Agentic Basics

Days 1–7

- Day 1: Orientation — read Official Exam Guide PDF + DEV.to breakdown. Register at Skilljar.
- Day 2: Claude 101 (13 lessons, claudecertifications.com). Tutorials Dojo study guide. 20 Qs CertSafari.
- Day 3: Domain 4 (22%) — Prompt Engineering. Messages API, structured JSON, nullable fields. Scenario 6.
- Day 4: Domain 1 Pt 1 (27%) — Agentic loop lifecycle. stop_reason 'tool_use' vs 'end_turn'. Anti-patterns.
- Day 5: Domain 1 Pt 2 — Coordinator + Task tool. Subagent explicit context. Scenario 3.
- Days 6–7: Domain 2 intro — Tool design, MCP config, error schema. 30-question mixed mock.

WEEK 2
Advanced Domains + All 6 Scenarios

Days 8–14

- Day 8: Domain 3 (20%) — CLAUDE.md hierarchy. Claude Code in Action lessons 1–7.
- Day 9: Domain 3 CI/CD — Scenario 5: -p flag, --output-format json, .claude/rules/ YAML.
- Day 10: Domain 5 (13%) — Haiku/Sonnet/Opus tradeoffs. AI Fluency Foundations. Scenario 1.
- Day 11: Domain 2 deep-dive (18%) — MCP hooks, PostToolUse, 3 tool definitions from scratch.
- Day 12: Scenarios mastery — write 3 key decisions for all 6 scenarios from memory.
- Days 13–14: Anti-Patterns guide + First full timed mock exam on CertSafari. Review all wrong answers.

WEEK 3
Mock Exams + Final Polish + Exam Day

Days 15–20

- Day 15: Weak-domain repair — re-read Official Guide for 2 lowest-scoring domains. 30 focused Qs.
- Day 16: Udemy practice exam + Second full timed mock on CertSafari. Target 720+.
- Day 17: Build personal cheat sheet: domain weights, 6 scenario decisions, anti-patterns.
- Days 18–19: Light review — read cheat sheet twice. 20-question quiz on weakest subdomain. REST.
- Day 20 (EXAM): Read cheat sheet once, put it away. Think architect, not trivia player.

Week 1 — Foundations + Prompting + Agentic Basics (Days 1–7)

Day 1
Orientation — Exam Structure

- Download & read Official CCA-F Exam Guide PDF — note every domain and skill listed

  → Official Exam Guide PDF
- Read the DEV.to deep-dive: 5 Domains + 6 Scenarios — understand the full landscape

  → dev.to deep-dive article
- Register for the exam at anthropic.skilljar.com — a deadline makes you study smarter

  → anthropic.skilljar.com

Day 2
Claude Fundamentals — Claude 101

- Complete Claude 101 — all 13 lessons, free, no signup required

  → claudecertifications.com
- Read Tutorials Dojo CCA-F Study Guide — skim all domains, read Domain 4 in full

  → tutorialsdojo.com
- Do 20 Domain 4 practice Qs on CertSafari — write down every wrong answer

  → certsafari.com

Day 3
Domain 4 — Prompt Engineering (22%)

- Read Anthropic docs: Messages API, system prompts, few-shot examples, JSON, nullable fields

  → docs.anthropic.com
- Study Scenario 6 (Structured Data Extraction): JSON schema, batch processing, nullables
- Do 25 Domain 4 Qs on CertSafari — focus on structured output and context management

  → certsafari.com

Day 4
Domain 1 Pt 1 — Agentic Loop (27%)

- Read Anthropic docs: Agent SDK, stop_reason 'tool_use' vs 'end_turn', tool result appending

  → docs.anthropic.com
- Study GitHub community guide: model-driven decision trees vs hard-coded, anti-patterns

  → github.com/paullarionov
- Write the full loop from memory: request → stop_reason → execute → return → repeat

Day 5
Domain 1 Pt 2 — Multi-Agent Patterns

- Study hub-and-spoke coordinator: Task tool, subagents need explicit context — NO auto-inherit

  → docs.anthropic.com
- Deep-dive Scenario 3 (Multi-Agent Research): decompose → delegate → aggregate
- Do 25 Domain 1 Qs on CertSafari — subdomains 1.3, 1.4, 1.5

  → certsafari.com

Days 6–7
Domain 2 Intro + Mixed Practice

- Read Anthropic docs: Tool Use, MCP server config, error responses (errorCategory, isRetryable)

  → docs.anthropic.com
- Study Scenario 4 (Dev Productivity): built-in tools — Read, Write, Bash, Grep, Glob
- Take 30-question mixed mock on CertSafari — record domain scores, identify 2 weakest

  → certsafari.com

Week 2 — Advanced Domains + All 6 Scenarios (Days 8–14)

Day 8
Domain 3 — Claude Code Config (20%)

- Read Claude Code docs: CLAUDE.md hierarchy — user, project, and directory-level scoping
  → docs.anthropic.com
- Start Claude Code in Action on claudecertifications.com — lessons 1–7
  → claudecertifications.com
- Write a sample CLAUDE.md file — 3 scoped rules, 1 path-restricted rule

Day 9
Domain 3 CI/CD & Advanced Claude Code

- Complete Claude Code in Action — lessons 8–15: CI/CD pipeline, hooks, GitHub integration
  → claudecertifications.com
- Study Scenario 5: -p flag, --output-format json, session isolation, false positive reduction
- Study GitHub guide: .claude/rules/ YAML frontmatter, context:fork, allowed-tools
  → github.com/daronyondem

Day 10
Domain 5 — Production Safety (13%)

- Read Anthropic docs: model overview — Haiku vs Sonnet vs Opus: cost, speed, capability
  → docs.anthropic.com
- Complete AI Fluency Foundations (13 lessons free) — 4D Framework for safety questions
  → claudecertifications.com
- Study Scenario 1 (Customer Support): escalation vs resolve, programmatic prerequisite gates

Day 11
Domain 2 Deep Dive — Tool Design & MCP

- Re-read Anthropic MCP docs: server config, tool distribution, PostToolUse interception
  → docs.anthropic.com
- Write 3 tool definitions from scratch: simple, nested schema, proper error structure
- Do 30 Domain 2 Qs on CertSafari
  → certsafari.com

Day 12
All 6 Scenarios — Mastery Day

- For each of the 6 scenarios: write 3 key architectural decisions from memory — no notes
- Check answers against Official Exam Guide + DEV.to breakdown — mark any gaps
  → dev.to article
- Watch curated video tutorials on claudecertifications.com — focus agentic + MCP content
  → claudecertifications.com

Days 13–14
Anti-Patterns + First Full Mock

- Read Anti-Patterns guide on claudecertifications.com — memorise top 5 architectural mistakes
  → claudecertifications.com
- First full timed mock on CertSafari — all domains, no pausing, exam conditions
  → certsafari.com
- Review every wrong answer in full. List bottom 2 domains for Week 3 focus.

Week 3 — Final Polish + Mock Exams + Exam Day (Days 15–20)

Day 15
Weak Domain Repair

- Re-read Official Exam Guide sections for 2 lowest-scoring domains — read slowly

  → Official Exam Guide PDF
- Re-read corresponding Anthropic docs sections for those same domains

  → docs.anthropic.com
- Do 30 focused Qs on weakest domain — domain mode, not random mix

  → certsafari.com

Day 16
Udemy Exam + 2nd Full Mock

- Take Udemy practice exam (Tutorials Dojo) — different question style than CertSafari

  → udemy.com — CCA-F Practice Exams
- Review all wrong answers. Note patterns: same domain? same mistake type?
- Take second full timed mock on CertSafari — target score 720+

  → certsafari.com

Day 17
Cheat Sheet + Scenario Recall

- Build 1-page cheat sheet: domain weights, 6 scenario titles, stop_reason values, anti-patterns
- For each scenario: say aloud 3 most important architectural decisions — if stuck, re-read it
- Do 20 Qs on CertSafari — only the domain you're least confident in

  → certsafari.com

Days 18–19
Weekend — Final Light Review

- Read cheat sheet twice: once slowly, once quickly as a scan
- Re-read exam logistics on Skilljar: time limit, question count, 4-of-6 selection

  → anthropic.skilljar.com
- One final 20-question quiz — weakest subdomain only. Then REST.

  → certsafari.com

Day 20
EXAM DAY — You're Ready!

- Read cheat sheet once, put it away. Think architect, not trivia player.
- REMEMBER: subagents do NOT inherit context — you must pass it explicitly.
- REMEMBER: stop_reason 'tool_use' = loop continues | 'end_turn' = done.

All 3 Weeks
Key Mindset Reminders

- Every question = real production scenario. Ask 'what would actually work?'
- Read full explanations for every wrong answer — not just the correct letter.
- Don't rely on prompt instructions for compliance — use programmatic gates.

Exam Tips from the Community

Think Like an Architect

Every question is a real production scenario. Ask: 'What would actually work in production?' — not 'what does this parameter do?'

Never treat the exam as a vocabulary test. It rewards architectural judgement.

Domain 1 is 27% — Master It First

Agentic Architecture is the biggest domain. Know the full loop cold:

send request → check stop_reason → execute tools → return results → repeat.

Prompt Instructions ≠ Guaranteed Compliance

When deterministic compliance is required (e.g. verify identity before financial ops), prompt instructions alone have a non-zero failure rate.

Use programmatic prerequisite gates instead.

Know Your stop_reason Values

'tool_use' means loop continues.
'end_turn' means done.

Never check natural language signals or set arbitrary iteration caps as loop termination.

Subagents Don't Inherit Context

Very common exam trap: subagents do NOT automatically receive the coordinator's conversation history.

You MUST explicitly pass context in every subagent prompt — every time.

Understand the Reasoning, Not Just the Answer

Multiple exam-takers: understanding why an answer is correct matters more than memorising the option.

Always read the full explanation, not just the correct letter.

AI Copilot Self-Study Prompt Ideas — Copy and use with any AI assistant

Generate Practice Questions

```
Generate 10 multiple-choice exam questions for the CCA-F exam covering Domain 1: Agentic Architecture. Include 4 options per question and explain the correct answer. Make them scenario-based, not trivia.
```

Explain the Agentic Loop

```
Explain the agentic loop lifecycle in Claude step by step: what happens when stop_reason is 'tool_use' vs 'end_turn', how tool results are appended to conversation history, and what anti-patterns to avoid.
```

Design a Multi-Agent System

```
Design a hub-and-spoke multi-agent architecture for a research system with a coordinator and 3 subagents: search, analyze, synthesize. Explain context passing, error handling, and when to use parallel invocation.
```

Quiz Me on a Scenario

```
I'm preparing for the CCA-F exam. Quiz me on Scenario 3: Multi-Agent Research System. Ask me 5 architectural decision questions, then evaluate my reasoning and show the better approach.
```

List Anti-Patterns

```
List the top 10 anti-patterns an architect must avoid when building Claude-powered systems. For each: name it, explain why it fails, and show the correct approach. Focus on the CCA-F domains.
```

Build a Cheat Sheet

```
Create a one-page CCA-F cheat sheet: 5 domain names and weights, 6 scenario titles, agentic loop stop_reason values, CLAUDE.md hierarchy levels, and 5 exam tips from people who passed.
```